HEALTH ANXIETY WORKBOOK

Stop Googling Symptoms & Start Living

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WHAT IS HEALTH ANXIETY?

Health anxiety (formerly hypochondria/Illness Anxiety Disorder) is:

An intense fear that you have or will develop a serious illness,

despite medical reassurance that you're healthy.

COMMON PATTERNS:

- Googling symptoms repeatedly
- Checking body for signs of illness
- Seeking reassurance from doctors/loved ones
- Avoiding medical info OR obsessively consuming it
- Interpreting normal body sensations as dangerous
- Believing the worst-case scenario is happening
- Brief relief after reassurance, then anxiety returns

Which patterns do I relate to?

THE REASSURANCE-SEEKING CYCLE

This is the trap that keeps health anxiety alive:

1. TRIGGER: Notice a body sensation or hear about an illness
2. THOUGHT: 'What if this is something serious?'
3. ANXIETY: Fear/panic rises, body produces MORE symptoms
4. BEHAVIOR: Google, check body, call doctor, ask partner
5. BRIEF RELIEF: 'Okay maybe I'm fine...'
6. DOUBT RETURNS: 'But what if they missed something?'
7. REPEAT: The cycle starts over, often worse

WHY REASSURANCE DOESN'T WORK:

- Each reassurance teaches your brain it NEEDED reassurance
- Tolerance builds - you need more reassurance each time
- It prevents you from learning you can tolerate uncertainty
- It keeps the anxiety alive instead of letting it naturally pass

My most common reassurance-seeking behavior:

BODY SCANNING & MISINTERPRETATION

Your anxious brain is HYPER-AWARE of body sensations.

Normal sensations get catastrophic interpretations:

Sensation	Anxious Thought	More Likely Cause
Headache	Brain tumor	Tension, dehydration, screen time
Heart racing	Heart attack	Anxiety, caffeine, exercise
Stomach pain	Cancer	Stress, diet, gas
Dizziness	Stroke	Anxiety, standing up fast, hunger
Tingling	MS/nerve damage	Sitting position, anxiety, cold
Fatigue	Chronic illness	Poor sleep, stress, normal variation

MY misinterpretations:

Sensation:_____ Anxious thought:_____ Likely cause:_____

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COGNITIVE DISTORTIONS IN HEALTH ANXIETY

Catastrophizing:	Jumping to the worst possible outcome
Probability overestimation:	Believing rare illnesses are likely for YOU
Confirmation bias:	Noticing only info that confirms your fear
Emotional reasoning:	'I FEEL sick, so I must BE sick'
Mind reading:	'The doctor looked concerned, something must be wrong'
Discounting positives:	Ignoring normal test results, clean bills of health

My most common distortion: _____

Evidence AGAINST my health fear:

What a friend would say to me:

THOUGHT RECORD - HEALTH WORRY #1

Date: _____ Symptom/trigger: _____

Anxious thought: _____

Anxiety level (0-100): _____

What illness am I afraid of? _____

Evidence FOR this fear:

Evidence AGAINST this fear:

More balanced thought:

Anxiety level AFTER (0-100): _____

Did I seek reassurance? Y / N If yes, what happened?

Alternative action I took instead:

THOUGHT RECORD - HEALTH WORRY #2

Date: _____ Symptom/trigger: _____

Anxious thought: _____

Anxiety level (0-100): _____

What illness am I afraid of? _____

Evidence FOR this fear:

Evidence AGAINST this fear:

More balanced thought:

Anxiety level AFTER (0-100): _____

Did I seek reassurance? Y / N If yes, what happened?

Alternative action I took instead:

THOUGHT RECORD - HEALTH WORRY #3

Date: _____ Symptom/trigger: _____

Anxious thought: _____

Anxiety level (0-100): _____

What illness am I afraid of? _____

Evidence FOR this fear:

Evidence AGAINST this fear:

More balanced thought:

Anxiety level AFTER (0-100): _____

Did I seek reassurance? Y / N If yes, what happened?

Alternative action I took instead:

THOUGHT RECORD - HEALTH WORRY #4

Date: _____ Symptom/trigger: _____

Anxious thought: _____

Anxiety level (0-100): _____

What illness am I afraid of? _____

Evidence FOR this fear:

Evidence AGAINST this fear:

More balanced thought:

Anxiety level AFTER (0-100): _____

Did I seek reassurance? Y / N If yes, what happened?

Alternative action I took instead:

THOUGHT RECORD - HEALTH WORRY #5

Date: _____ Symptom/trigger: _____

Anxious thought: _____

Anxiety level (0-100): _____

What illness am I afraid of? _____

Evidence FOR this fear:

Evidence AGAINST this fear:

More balanced thought:

Anxiety level AFTER (0-100): _____

Did I seek reassurance? Y / N If yes, what happened?

Alternative action I took instead:

BEHAVIORAL EXPERIMENTS

Test your beliefs! What actually happens when you DON'T check?

- Don't Google symptoms for 24 hours
- Don't check your body for 1 day
- Don't ask anyone for reassurance for 48 hours
- Wait 1 week before calling the doctor about a new symptom
- Notice a symptom and do NOTHING about it

MY EXPERIMENT:

What I'll do differently: _____

What I predict will happen: _____

What ACTUALLY happened: _____

Anxiety level during (0-100): _____

What I learned: _____

INTEROCEPTIVE EXPOSURE

Learn that body sensations are NOT dangerous by creating them on purpose:

Exercise	Sensation Created	Fear
Spin in a chair (30 sec)	Dizziness	___/10
Run in place (60 sec)	Heart racing, breathlessness	___/10
Hold breath (30 sec)	Chest tightness	___/10
Stare at a light then read	Visual disturbance	___/10
Tense all muscles (60 sec)	Muscle ache, tingling	___/10
Breathe through a straw (30 sec)	Breathlessness	___/10
Shake head side to side (30 sec)	Dizziness, disorientation	___/10

KEY INSIGHT: The sensation passed. Nothing bad happened.

What I learned: _____

REDUCING REASSURANCE-SEEKING

Gradual plan to stop seeking reassurance:

Step 1: Notice every time you seek reassurance (tally it)

Step 2: Delay reassurance by 30 minutes (sit with uncertainty)

Step 3: Delay by 2 hours

Step 4: Delay until next day

Step 5: Don’t seek it at all - use coping skill instead

INSTEAD OF REASSURANCE, I WILL:

- Say to myself: ’I can tolerate this uncertainty.’
- Do a grounding exercise (5-4-3-2-1 senses)
- Accept the thought without engaging: ’There’s that thought again.’
- Remind myself: ’Anxiety is not evidence.’
- Do an activity that requires focus

My reassurance-seeking tally this week: _____

Times I resisted seeking reassurance: _____

WEEKLY SYMPTOM WORRY TRACKER - WEEK 1

Mon	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Tue	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Wed	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Thu	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Fri	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Sat	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Sun	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N

Times I Googled: ___ Times I checked body: ___

Times I asked for reassurance: ___

Times I resisted & coped: ___

What helped most: _____

WEEKLY SYMPTOM WORRY TRACKER - WEEK 2

Mon	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Tue	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Wed	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Thu	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Fri	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Sat	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Sun	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N

Times I Googled: ___ Times I checked body: ___

Times I asked for reassurance: ___

Times I resisted & coped: ___

What helped most: _____

WEEKLY SYMPTOM WORRY TRACKER - WEEK 3

Mon	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Tue	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Wed	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Thu	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Fri	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Sat	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Sun	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N

Times I Googled: ___ Times I checked body: ___

Times I asked for reassurance: ___

Times I resisted & coped: ___

What helped most: _____

WEEKLY SYMPTOM WORRY TRACKER - WEEK 4

Mon	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Tue	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Wed	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Thu	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Fri	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Sat	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Sun	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N

Times I Googled: ___ Times I checked body: ___

Times I asked for reassurance: ___

Times I resisted & coped: ___

What helped most: _____

WEEKLY SYMPTOM WORRY TRACKER - WEEK 5

Mon	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Tue	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Wed	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Thu	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Fri	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Sat	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N
Sun	Symptom:_____	Fear:_____	Anx:__/10	Googled? Y/N	Checked? Y/N

Times I Googled: ___ Times I checked body: ___

Times I asked for reassurance: ___

Times I resisted & coped: ___

What helped most: _____

WHEN TO SEE A DOCTOR VS ANXIETY

SEE A DOCTOR IF:

- New symptom that lasts more than 2 weeks
- Sudden severe pain
- High fever that won’t break
- Blood in stool/urine
- Unexplained weight loss (10+ lbs)
- A lump that’s growing

IT’S PROBABLY ANXIETY IF:

- You’ve been reassured by a doctor already
- Symptoms come and go with stress
- You’ve had similar fears before that resolved
- Dr. Google is your main source of concern
- Symptoms shift to whatever you read about last

MINDFULNESS OF BODY SENSATIONS

RESPONSE PREVENTION PLAN

MY HEALTH ANXIETY ACTION PLAN

UNCERTAINTY TOLERANCE PRACTICE

COGNITIVE DEFUSION EXERCISES

MY SAFETY BEHAVIORS TO ELIMINATE

EXPOSURE HIERARCHY

VALUES-BASED LIVING

MY RECOVERY PROGRESS